Modals: must, should, ought to

Objective: To express obligation, prohibition and advice using the modals **must**, **should** and **ought to**, for example when talking about peace and good citizenship.

The idea in two lines: Modals add meaning to the main verb. *Must* expresses strong obligation (often from the speaker), while *should* and *ought to* give advice or say what is right to do.

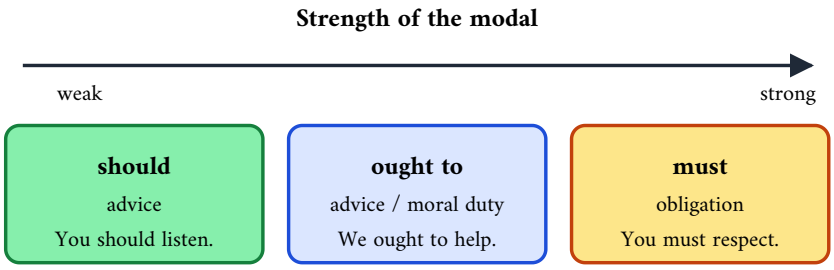


Figure 1: Should and ought to give advice; must expresses strong obligation.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Form:** modal + base form, with no -s in the third person: *She must leave*, not *She musts leaves.*
2. **Must:** strong obligation or necessity: *Citizens must obey the law.*
3. **Mustn't:** prohibition (it is forbidden): *You mustn't use violence.*
4. **Should / ought to:** advice or what is morally right: *We should / ought to solve conflicts peacefully. Ought* is followed by *to.*
5. **Negatives:** *shouldn't, ought not to*; questions: *Should I …?*
6. **Have to:** obligation from outside (rules); *don't have to* = no obligation, which is different from *mustn't.*

🟢 Examples

1. Give advice to a friend who is always fighting: **Answer:** You *should* control your anger and talk calmly. **Explanation:** advice, not an order.

2. Express a school rule about cheating: **Answer:** Pupils *mustn't* cheat in exams. **Explanation:** prohibition.
3. Correct the mistake: "Nations ought respect human rights." **Answer:** Nations *ought to* respect human rights.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Adding *to* after must or should: *must to go* ✗ → **must go** ✓.
- Forgetting **to** after *ought*.
- Confusing **mustn't** (forbidden) with **don't have to** (not necessary).
- Adding -s or -ed to the modal or to the verb after it.

🟡 Quick review

- Modal + base form, no -s.
- must = strong obligation; mustn't = prohibition.
- should = ought to = advice.
- ought + to + verb.
- mustn't ≠ don't have to.

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